



LONDON ENGLAND

Roast Beef and Beefeaters

So associated are the British with traditional roast beef that the French call them “les rosbifs,” but, far from being insulted, the nation still takes pride in its favorite Sunday lunch. Top London restaurants and down-to-earth pubs alike serve up oven-roasted beef with Yorkshire pudding, horseradish, and gravy – perfect fodder for visiting the old England symbolized by the dish.



“When Mighty Roast Beef was the Englishman’s food, It ennobled our brains and enriched our blood,” wrote Henry Fielding in his jingoistic ballad, *The Roast Beef of Old England*, evoking a nostalgic view of English national identity way back in 1731. The song was taken up as an unofficial anthem, sung in theaters and at naval dinners, and William Hogarth named a satirical painting after it in 1748: subtitled *The Gate of Calais*, it depicts starving French soldiers drooling as a side of beef is borne into an English tavern.

The origins of the dish itself are more prosaic. In the days before domestic ovens, households used to roast their beef in the baker’s oven on Sundays, the day of rest. Yorkshire pudding, a batter cooked in the juices from the roasting meat, had been added by 1747, when English cooking writer Hannah Glasse included a recipe in *The Art of Cookery Made Plain and Easy*.

Old-fashioned London restaurants such as Rules and Simpson’s in the Strand continue to serve old English roast beef with all the trimmings in historic surroundings, and Londoners vie to nominate the best pub roast. Alongside the Yorkshire pudding, which should be light and fluffy, classic accompaniments are

crunchy roast potatoes and seasonal vegetables, piquant horseradish sauce and thick gravy. Prime cuts of rib and sirloin from prized Aberdeen Angus and Hereford herds yield the most tender, juicy meat, best served rare and thinly sliced.

Fuel up at one of these before a foray into old England. Start at the Tower of London, guarded by its Beefeaters, so called because these royal bodyguards were allowed to eat as much beef as they wanted from the king’s table. Decide for yourself if “our soldiers were brave and our courtiers were good,” as Fielding sentimentally suggested in his ballad: the 11th-century White Tower is where two little princes were imprisoned by King Richard III, while at Tower Green, countless Englishmen and women, among them Henry VIII’s wife Anne Boleyn, lost their heads.

For a glimpse into Hogarthian England, visit Sir John Soane’s Museum, a perfectly preserved 18th-century house where you can see the artist’s *A Rake’s Progress* and *The Election*, satirizing the world in which Fielding’s rousing ode to roast beef took such hold. From here one can explore the Inns of Court, up Fleet Street and past the Old Bailey and into the back streets of St. James’s and Mayfair, all redolent of a past when Englishmen “had stomachs to eat and to fight.”

Three Days in London

London has so much to offer that visitors need to plan ahead, especially if time is short. But it’s possible to pack in a few modern marvels among the traditional sights.

DAY ONE Start at the **Tower of London**, with its Crown Jewels and Beefeaters, then take a look at Tower Bridge. Walk through the City of London to **St. Paul’s Cathedral**, then cross the Thames to visit the **Tate Modern** gallery in the afternoon.

DAY TWO Take an early stroll in Green Park to see **Buckingham Palace**. Ride the **London Eye** for a bird’s-eye view of the city, then go to **Covent Garden** for lunch – perhaps at Rules. Spend the afternoon with the antiquities at the **British Museum**, or walk through Holborn to **Sir John Soane’s Museum**.

DAY THREE In the morning see **Big Ben**, the **Houses of Parliament**, and **Westminster Abbey**, and then in the afternoon choose from one of the city’s other exceptional museums, clustered together in South Kensington: the **Science Museum**, **Natural History Museum**, or **Victoria and Albert Museum**.

Essentials

GETTING THERE

London has three **international airports**, with public transportation to the center. Get around on **foot** or by **bus** or **subway train** (“tube”).

WHERE TO STAY

The Hoxton (inexpensive) is chic and fun, but slightly out of the center. www.hoxtonhotels.com
The Hallam (moderate) is a bargain, moderately priced but central. www.hallamhotel.com
The Savoy (expensive), one of London’s *grande dame* hotels, has been recently overhauled. www.fairmont.com/savoy

TOURIST INFORMATION

1 Lower Regent Street; www.visitlondon.com

